



8 Prose other than fiction: rhetoric and structure

Literary forms · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Non-fiction prose (essays, speeches, memoir, journalism) is analysed for rhetorical strategy: how the writer builds an argument or persuades through structure, tone, appeals (ethical, emotional, logical), and stylistic choices such as repetition or rhetorical questions. Unlike fiction, the implied 'author' of non-fiction is generally treated as closer to the real writer, though the crafted persona on the page should still be analysed as a constructed rhetorical stance.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Consider an invented opening line of a speech: 'I did not come here to be believed; I came here to be heard.' A model analytical point: 'The antithesis between 'believed' and 'heard' lowers the immediate stakes of persuasion, disarming potential scepticism while still asserting a right to speak — an ethical appeal that builds credibility before any argument is made.'

Quick check · multiple choice

In rhetorical analysis, an 'ethical appeal' (ethos) refers to:

- A A statistic or piece of logical evidence
- B An appeal to the audience's emotions
- C An appeal based on the credibility, character, or authority of the speaker/writer
- D A description of a physical setting

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Analyse the following invented excerpt from a memoir for rhetorical and structural technique: 'I have told this story many times, and each time I leave something out, not because I forget, but because some truths only bear repeating in pieces.' Discuss what this reveals about the memoir's approach to structure and reliability, and identify at least one rhetorical device. [20]

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [20]

- Point 1: the admission of selective repetition ('I leave something out... in pieces') foregrounds the memoir's structure as deliberately fragmented rather than linear or complete, inviting the reader to expect gaps.
- Point 2: the paradox ('not because I forget, but because...') functions rhetorically to preempt accusations of unreliability, reframing omission as a form of care rather than a failure of memory.
- Point 3: the reflective, self-aware tone builds ethos, positioning the narrator as a trustworthy, thoughtful interpreter of their own past despite acknowledged gaps.
- Point 4: this passage likely signals a fragmented or non-chronological structure for the whole memoir, since piecemeal truth-telling is announced as method.
- Conclusion: argue that in non-fiction, structural honesty about omission can itself be a persuasive/rhetorical strategy that builds trust.

Quick check answer

C. Ethos concerns the speaker's credibility or moral authority, distinct from logos (logic) and pathos (emotion).

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English A: Literature guide (2019).

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